CMM 365 · STRATEGIC WRITING FOR PR AND ADVERTISING · SPRING 2025 · SPRING HILL COLLEGE

ABOUT THIS PIECE

A social media strategy for Purple Alert

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WHAT IT IS

A social media strategy for @shcpurplealert, the Spring Hill account I founded. It covers the brand overview, platforms, post types, and example posts. This is an excerpt.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How the account's voice, campus humor and the Purp mascot, carries through every type of post.

Crafting Compelling Social Media Content

A social strategy for @shcpurplealert · Katherine Conklin · Excerpt: strategy, post types, and examples

Brand overview: @shcpurplealert

@shcpurplealert is a student-run (I am actually the founder!) Instagram account based at Spring Hill College in Mobile, Alabama. It blends campus humor, real-time event updates, memes, and culturally relevant commentary aimed at the Spring Hill student body. The account features a recurring purple humanoid badger mascot named "Purp," known for his tracksuit, gold chain, and sunglasses. The tone is playful, clever, Gen Z focused, and grounded in the student experience. The brand's strength lies in its relatability and its ability to spread hyper-local news quickly. It's not corporate; it's like a virtual friend on campus, especially helpful for new students.

Platforms

- **Instagram:** the platform where @shcpurplealert was born and has the most active audience. Also where the badger mascot "Purp" already has a strong presence.
- **Threads:** a newer platform by Meta, ideal for text-based and micro interactions. Many SHC students follow this platform because it was made by Instagram.
- **TikTok:** expanding into TikTok would allow @shcpurplealert to reach an even wider student and prospective student audience with video content, skits, and trends.

Platform strategy and post concepts

Instagram

Instagram is @shcpurplealert's "home base." It's where most of the audience already lives, engages, and expects content from the brand. This platform supports all kinds of visual content, such as static images, carousels, Stories, and Reels, and thrives on aesthetic but relatable posts. It's also where the "Purp" mascot was created and built an identity (basically an off-brand Beaumont). Instagram allows a balance between entertainment and information, supports high engagement via Stories and DMs, and rewards brand consistency and aesthetic design.

Strategy

- Use a consistent visual style and voice across all posts.
- Alternate between humor, event promotion, and "day in the life" content.
- Use Stories and Reels to provide timely updates or hype events.
- Maintain high audience engagement with polls, Q&As, meme formats, relatable captions, trending audio, and hashtags.

Post types

- Carousel memes and information dumps for each week featuring important events or updates
- Reels to showcase events, trending challenges, and day in the life
- Campus-related humor with photos of Purp and students
- "Almost Friday" pictures submitted by students

Threads

Threads is Meta's response to Twitter/X, focused on short-form, conversational content. SHC students who follow @shcpurplealert likely also engage here, although I found some contradictions in my research. According to experts, Threads is supposed to feel more casual and is ideal for testing hot takes, live reactions, and sparking interaction without needing a polished visual. I, on the other hand, prefer to use it for text-heavy information that would otherwise go unnoticed on a visual platform like Instagram. Threads supports a conversational tone and real-time interaction, which aligns with PR principles of responsiveness and message clarity. It also promotes thought leadership and transparency, key to campus trust.

Strategy

- Use the platform to react in real time to campus happenings.
- Feature polls, open-ended questions, and micro-memes that are relevant to the SHC experience.
- Expand brand personality in a format that encourages spontaneous community conversation.

Post types

- Polls and interactive threads
- Purp's commentary on current events regarding campus
- Longer articles, "TL;DR for Instagram," including links
- Spring Hillian newspaper articles

TikTok

While @shcpurplealert doesn't currently have a strong TikTok presence, it could be the best platform for growth among current and prospective students. It allows posts to be seen by more people based on its virality algorithm, creativity trends, and fun skits. It's also a perfect medium to bring the mascot Purp to life through performance and student interaction. TikTok supports emotional and experiential storytelling, which is a key PR writing skill. It allows "showing" over "telling" and can reach audiences beyond campus with relatable student life content. The algorithm favors small accounts when content is creative and niche.

Strategy

- Use trending audio and formats to make campus-specific humor that can also be relatable to all students.
- Let Purp be the face of the account through acting, dancing, and satire.
- Showcase events like the Badger Dash or campus traditions in entertaining short videos.
- Collaborate with students for user-generated content and reactions.

Post types

- Trend-based skits and memes featuring Purp

- Event promotion
- Day in the life of a Spring Hill student content

Examples

Instagram post 1: Almost Friday graduation carousel (3 pictures)
Features graduation pictures with classic Almost Friday text over them, a weekly post for this account. Caption: "Almost Graduation! #AlmostFriday #Graduation #VivaLaHill #College." Location tag: Spring Hill College.

Instagram post 2: Almost finals meme carousel (3 pictures)
Features Purp in relatable situations. Caption: "Finals are almost over, badgers stay STRONG! #YouGotThis #FinalsSZN #VivaLaHill #CollegeLife #relatable." Location tag: Spring Hill College.

Instagram post 3: college transition advice carousel
Features comic-book-style Purp interacting and giving advice to incoming freshmen. Caption: "Attention Incoming Freshman! PURP is here to help answer the questions you really want to know, comment or DM if interested #CollegeAdvice #VivaLaHill." Location tag: Spring Hill College.

Instagram post 4: open-ended Story poll
Question: do you have specific questions? Answers are based on feedback, and results are posted as they come in.

Threads post concept
Share The Spring Hillian's newest article with the caption: "The Spring Hillian's new article… what do you think? :)"

TikTok post 1: "Day in the life (real badger edition)"
Concept: a glimpse into campus life, relatable and authentic content for prospective and current students. **Style:** vlog-style montage, casual. **Audio:** chill instrumental trending audio. **Caption:** "A regular day at SHC as Purp." **Hashtags:** #College #BadgerLife #VivaLaHill #DayInTheLife #Vlog #Relatable

- **Shot 1:** Morning. Purp stretches, makes the bed in the dorm, picks an outfit. Quick pan of a messy desk. Camera follows a hand reaching for a phone.
- **Shot 2:** Walking under the oaks to class. Cut to squirrels running. Light lens flare effect.
- **Shot 3:** In class, an over-the-shoulder POV shot of taking notes, then a wide shot of class discussion.
- **Shot 4:** Lunch at McKinney's, an unboxing shot opens to a chicken sandwich, drink, and fries. Crunch sound effects.
- **Shot 5:** Study session at CASA, a time lapse of typing and a highlighter gliding across a page, cut to "study face."
- **Shot 6:** Sunset on the hill, Purp laying back on the golf course, scrolling a phone, life is good.
- **Editing:** voiceover and subtitles.

TikTok post 2: "Spring Hill survival guide"
Concept: a funny and semi-serious list of things new students need to know about life at SHC. **Style:** comedy, labeled tips. **Audio:** voiceover narration with a background instrumental beat. **Caption:** "SHC,

where anything can happen." **Hashtags:** #CollegeTips #SHCSurvival #BadgerAdvice #CampusLife

- **Tip 1:** "Never trust Mobile weather." A clip of someone walking in the sun, then pouring rain minutes later.
- **Tip 2:** "You will never get used to the speed bumps." Clips of cars driving over speed bumps at different paces, drivers wincing comically.
- **Bonus tip:** "Eventually, you'll end up on @shcpurplealert, just embrace it."
- **Editing:** on-screen text for each tip, jump cuts, emojis, reaction captions, and a final "Good luck" outro.